

realistic to believe that a young couple will never buy any clothing? Since you rarely see a naked couple at church, I hardly think so.

KEEP IT SIMPLE

The budgeting system that we use is very simple, purposely. When I first began to counsel, I went to several bookstores and bought every budget book available because I needed a plan to help couples get started. Most of the budget books were written by accountants, and only another accountant could understand them. They had 30 pages of information to fill out. If most couples could do that, they probably wouldn't need a budget.

In fact, I believe a budget should be so simple that, if it takes more than an hour each month to maintain it, it's too complicated. So I began to consider: what is the simplest budgeting plan that anyone can have? It's the system that many of our grandparents used before there were many banks and checking accounts: envelopes. They kept their money in jars or envelopes. They had envelopes for the tithe, taxes, housing, food, and automobile. In our budget system, it takes 12 envelopes. On the outside of each envelope is noted the amount of money to be spent on that category each month.

For instance, if the total housing budget is \$750 per month, including the mortgage payment, utilities (average), telephone, and insurance, each allocation would be shown on the envelope, with the total being \$750. If you were paid twice a month, it would be divided proportionately, depending on when the payments were due. Since most rent or mortgage payments are due on the 1st of each month and other payments are not due until later in the month, the amount allocated per paycheck would have to be adjusted accordingly.